

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

PHILADELPHIA VIREO
Vireo philadelphicus

Rcd 2/2/01 upl

Location: Ft. Lyon Wildlife Easement; Las Animas; Bent County, Colorado

Date: October 8, 2000

Brandon Percival, Vic Zerbi and I were birding the Ft. Lyon Wildlife Easement near Las Animas the morning of the 8th. It was about 12:00 noon as we had spent some time searching for the Sharp-tailed Sandpiper (and not finding it that day). The easement is an extensive area of trees (mainly elm) scattered through a grassy area adjacent to John Martin Reservoir. We found the vireo after Vic had initially gotten a glimpse of the bird and lost it. It associated with a mixed flock of Orange-crowned and Yellow-rumped warblers, Ruby-crowned Kinglets, Mountain Chickadees and Brown Creepers. We finally located it in a medium-sized isolated tree along the path and it gave good beautiful clear views (with patience) from about 30 feet as it foraged in the crowns of the elms. It was deliberate in its motions and silent. I watched it with my B & L Elite 10x42 binoculars for about 10 minutes.

Description:

This was an adult bird. It was medium-small, about 5" long. We noted the very short tail, thick, short neck and stubby appearance. Above the bird was grayish; slightly yellower-green on the back and wings. There was a dark spot just down from the bend of the folded wing. The face was gray and it had an indistinct paler area below the eye, and a white supercilium curving over top of the eye. There was a short dark line extending from in front of the eye to just behind the eye. The bill was dark, short, strong and not pointed. Underneath the bird was quite yellow, washed overall yellow but quite intensely yellow on the breast. The undertail was pale yellow.

Similar Species:

Warblers have slender, sharp bills that lack the blunt tip of this bird's bill. Kinglets are also small-billed, flitty and not colored in the wing as this bird. The contrasting gray crown, dark line through the eye and lack of wingbars eliminate Bell's Vireo. Warbling Vireo is most similar, but it has light lores, and lacks the yellow center to the breast and throat; has a longer tail; lacks the black mark at the bend of the wing.

Experience with Species:

I have seen all of the Colorado vireos and most warblers. I have seen several Philadelphia Vireos in other states and five times before in Colorado.

This report was prepared from notes made immediately after observation.

Mark Janos
10 Sedum Ct.
Pueblo, CO 81001

Mark Janos